

FRESH START FINANCE
PRACTICAL FREE GUIDE

30-Day Credit Checklist

A clear path to review your reports, spot errors, and build habits that protect your credit profile.

01

Review what
shows up

02

Fix what
doesn't belong

03

Build a
sustainable routine

Important:

There is no guaranteed or instant improvement. Scores change depending on the model, the data used, and the time of calculation.

STEP 1

Know your starting point

Your credit report holds the information; your score is an estimate built from it. Start by checking all three reports, not just one number.

Before you open them

- Use a private connection and a trusted device.
- Request your reports from Equifax, Experian, and TransUnion.
- The CFPB identifies AnnualCreditReport.com as the authorized channel for free reports from the three national agencies.
- Save copies somewhere safe.
- Write down your review date:

Review line by line

- Name, addresses, and identity details.
- Open and closed accounts.
- Balances, limits, and payment status.
- Late payments, collections, and inquiries.
- Dates and creditor names.

Don't panic if the scores don't match.

You can have more than one score because the model, the data source, and the calculation date change.

Stop if you see something you don't recognize.

An unknown account or inquiry could be an error or a sign of identity theft. Don't share full account numbers, Social Security numbers, passwords, or photos of your reports in public comments or messages.

Checking your own credit doesn't lower your score; it's not treated the same as a lender's inquiry.

STEP 2

Dispute errors with evidence

An effective dispute points to the exact data, explains why it's wrong, and keeps a record of what was sent.

1. Identify

- ☐ Agency and report where it appears.
- ☐ Company that provided the data.
- ☐ Account, date, and incorrect field.

2. Gather

- ☐ Copy of the report with the item marked.
- ☐ Copies of receipts, statements, or supporting letters.
- ☐ A brief, specific explanation.

3. Send and log

- ☐ File the dispute with the credit agency.
- ☐ Also contact the company that reported the data.
- ☐ Save copies, confirmations, and dates.

4. Follow up

- ☐ Date sent: _____
- ☐ Confirmation number: _____
- ☐ Response date: _____

State the outcome you're requesting.

For example: correct the balance, update the payment status, or remove an account that isn't yours.

A dispute doesn't erase correct information.

Don't file a dispute just because a negative item is uncomfortable. If the information is correct, focus on positive habits and resolving the debt with the creditor according to your situation.

STEP 3

Build habits that count

No secret shortcuts. Consistency usually outweighs any “trick” promised on social media.

Pay on time

- Set reminders for every due date.
- If you use autopay, verify there are funds.
- If you're falling behind, contact the creditor soon.

Watch your utilization

- $\text{balance} \div \text{limit} \times 100$ — Example: $\$300 \div \$1,000 = 30\%$
- The CFPB advises against getting close to the limit and notes experts often recommend staying under 30%.
- Lower can be better, but there's no universal magic percentage.

Apply only for what you need

- Avoid several new applications in a short time.
- Compare costs and terms before applying.

Think before closing

- Review annual cost, age, and available limit.
- Closing a card can raise your total utilization.

You don't need to pay interest to build credit.

The CFPB notes you don't need to carry a balance; paying in full can reduce interest costs.

Prioritize housing, food, utilities, transportation, and health first. If you can't cover all payments, seek individual guidance from a nonprofit credit counseling organization or a qualified professional.

YOUR PLAN

Four weeks, one simple system

Check off each action as you complete it. If a task doesn't apply to you, write "N/A" to close the loop.

WEEK 01 Gather and review

- ☐ Get all three credit reports.
- ☐ Compare identity, accounts, balances, payments, collections, and inquiries.
- ☐ Make a list of questionable items without sharing sensitive information.

WEEK 02 Fix and organize

- ☐ Gather documents for each potential error.
- ☐ File justified disputes and log confirmations.
- ☐ Set up reminders or autopay you can sustain.

WEEK 03 Relieve pressure

- ☐ Calculate each card's utilization and the total.
- ☐ Choose a realistic amount to reduce balances without neglecting essential expenses.
- ☐ Avoid new applications while stabilizing the plan.

WEEK 04 Verify and repeat

- ☐ Confirm scheduled payments were processed.
- ☐ Update the dispute log and save responses.
- ☐ Pick a monthly date to review payments, balances, and alerts.

My goal for the next 30 days

First step _____ Review date _____

STAY ON TRACK

Your monthly review

Log only what you need to decide your next action. Keep this document somewhere private.

Account or goal	Due	Status	Next action

Quick check

- Confirmed payments.
- Balances and limits reviewed.
- Disputes updated.
- Unknown inquiries investigated.

Remember

- Changes can take time to show.
- Scores can vary between models.
- No one can guarantee a number of points.
- Don't pay for promises to erase correct information.

Next step:

Save this guide, pick your monthly date, and follow Fresh Start Finance for more educational content and simple actions.

REFERENCE

Official sources and next steps

Use official sources to verify rules, rights, and procedures before making a decision.

Consumer Financial Protection Bureau (CFPB)

- Understanding your score: consumerfinance.gov · Understand your credit score
- What a credit score is: consumerfinance.gov · What is a credit score?
- Habits for a good score: consumerfinance.gov · How do I get and keep a good credit score?
- Consumer reporting companies: consumerfinance.gov · Consumer reporting companies

Federal Trade Commission (FTC)

- Sample dispute letter: consumer.ftc.gov · Sample letter to credit bureaus

Protect your information

- Don't post your credit report or account numbers.
- Verify the site address before entering personal data.
- Be skeptical of guaranteed results or instant "fixes."
- If you suspect identity theft, act immediately through official channels.

This material is informational content, not financial advice. It doesn't offer personalized recommendations or guarantee score changes. For decisions about debt, credit, taxes, or legal matters, consider consulting a qualified professional who knows your situation.

Sources consulted in September 2026. Policies and recommendations may change.